In Cuba prior to the Revolution, Ian Lumsden explains in *Machos, Maricones and Gays: Cuba and Homosexuality*, the categories "macho" and "maricón" distinguished men based on their identification with traditional, stereotypically male or "macho" forms of public behavior (and implied sexual practices), rather than on their choice of sexual partners. A man could be "macho" and have sexual relations with other men, as long as he maintained the dominant or active role in the partnership. "Maricón" is a generally derogatory term for a man "whose comportment appeared effeminate and deviated from stereotypical masculinity."[27] Levels of stigma and prejudice against those identified as *maricones* was perhaps comparable to the stigma against homosexuals in the United States, but this prejudice could not accurately be described as "homophobia" since the very category "homosexual" – meaning a person with a sexual orientation towards those of the same sex – was not a meaningful category in the Cuban context.

Roger Lancaster describes a comparable system of beliefs and ideas in Nicaragua, where the term "cochón" parallels the use of "maricón" in Cuba. "The term marks and delimits a set of sexual practices that partially overlaps but is clearly not identical to our notion of the homosexual. The term specifies only certain practices in certain contexts. Some acts that we would describe as homosexual bear neither stigma nor an accompanying identity of any special sort whatsoever."[28]

These traditional ideas and categories grew out of Cuba's Spanish and African (and probably also indigenous, though the evidence in this regard is more murky) heritage. In the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, they were also influenced by the increasing presence of people and institutions from the United States. Imperialism, many authors have argued, is inherently gendered and sexualized. Edward Said offered the insight that Orientalism – the study of what Europeans defined as "the Orient" in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries – was part and parcel of European imperial endeavors. The Orient was depicted as fundamentally Other, passive, and feminized, awaiting European penetration. Later authors have built on these ideas and extended them to other parts of the world. In the case of Cuba, manly notions of conquest defined the relationship between the United States and Cuba